However well we plan, we all have food left over at times. Cooked chicken and ham are obvious candidates for soup, but you can make good use of many other leftovers, too.

making use of leftovers

The ideal home for leftovers is in comforting rustic-style soups. Add the ingredient sparingly to begin with, then use your discrimination to decide on balance, texture, and seasoning. Recycling food calls for ingenuity and skill, so never give in to temptation and use your soup pot as a receptacle, or your soup-making skills will acquire a poor reputation. Here are some thrifty ideas for using leftovers.



stale bread

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Stale white bread is the perfect starting point for making croûtons and croûtes (see p39), which are a welcome addition to a wide range of soups. Processed in a blender or food processor to form bread crumbs, stale bread is also an essential ingredient in the chilled Spanish soup Gazpacho (see p107).

cooked meat

Cooked chicken, turkey, and game are all excellent in soups, as is cooked ham. Cured meats such as chorizo and salami work equally well. In general, leftovers of red meats are not suitable for making soup, although the bones from cooked beef or lamb can go straight into the cooking pot for stock.



egg yolks and whites

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Making use of leftover egg yolks is never a problem. Whisk them into a hot soup toward the end of cooking—they will thicken it and give a velvety texture. Although less versatile, leftover egg whites are useful for clarifying consommé.